Home Run

Talk of an old-age home and the vision it throws up is of a depressing homestead with abandoned parents spending the last days of their lives in penury and desolation. It's a fate that many senior citizens are pre-empting. A changing mindset and increased disposable income over the past decade is leading many of them, particularly in the upper middle and high income segments, to consider independent living in retirement communities. Houses built for the elderly, PwC India estimates, constitute 10-15 per cent of the total market.

Revathi Bhasker, 72, has no cause to regret her decision. A decade ago, she and her (now deceased) husband, S.K. Bhasker, relocated to the verdant surroundings of Covai Coimbatore after he retired from a bank job. "We spent most of our life in Mumbai. But, in large cities, hardly anyone talks to each other. Often, you don't even know who lives next door," she says. Senior living communities are different from that perspective, she feels. "Everyone is connected together through retirement and old age. The problems are similar and the empathy, higher. There is no one to impress nor any expectations to fulfil. So, everyone lives together like an extended family, participating in each other's joys and sorrows," she says.

Building on that sentiment, real estate developers are positioning retirement homes as a new lifestyle option for seniors and offering options across price segments. In the north, Delhi NCR is the major hub of senior living communities, whereas down South, Chennai, Coimbatore and Bengaluru in particular have a high concentration of such properties.

Antara in Dehradun is an outlier, catering to a high net worth clientele, with the average cost of a dwelling ranging from Rs 3.5-4 crore, depending on size. Most other players, such as

RISE OF AGE TECH

With digital and remote monitoring on the rise, seniors now have an array of gadgets that are less intrusive and can be seamlessly integrated into their daily lives, helping them live independently



EASYFONE

A Seniorworld product, it can be configured remotely by family members and allows them to initiate calls on speaker mode if the senior isn't answering calls and has phone on silent mode

AI-POWERED SMART LAMP



They call it Nobi. An offering by Welldercare Agetech, it uses optical sensors to detect and trigger an emergency response in case an eldely person falls and is unable to get up



TRACKING DEVICE

TigerTRACK, a wearable personal security device with GPS tracker, SOS button and phone, can track location and autodial emergency numbers even without a cellphone

SMART PILL DISPENSER

An automatic medication dispenser by Med-E-Lert that buzzes to remind seniors to take their medicines as per their schedule



TELEHEALTH MONITOR



A portable, pocket-sized device, RHEMOS can measure BP, heart rate, ECG, respiratory rate, sugar, blood oxygen and temperature via self-administrated tests and transmit results directly to the app or to the cloud for remote diagnostics